

no longer enough. "It had become a chore. I thought to myself I'd somehow get to the 2024 Olympics. If I qualified, great. If I didn't, that was also fine. Whatever happened, I was done with shooting. I wasn't going to step into the shooting range ever again," she says.

The fun had gone out of the sport. "For someone on the outside, it looked as if I was doing fine. I was still part of the Indian team and shooting decent scores. But I was not happy inside. I didn't like shooting. There was this constant feeling *ki nahi ho raha hai* (that it's not happening). Shooting was becoming more like a job for me. Every single day it felt as if I was doing the same thing. I just didn't like the monotony," she says.

Manu had felt this way many years before. Before she took up shooting at 16, she had been a boxer. "Boxing was the first sport I really loved, but I left it because the schedule had just become really monotonous. I was just doing the same thing every day. I left that sport despite really loving it. It had become more of a job for me. It was the same for shooting. It just didn't excite me. On the other hand, it just made me really nervous. It just drove me crazy, and then I was like, 'I can't shoot like that anymore,'" she says.

Quitting the sport was an idea she'd been flirting with for a few months already, but last June was when she actually started making plans for what life would look like once she put down her pistols for the last time.

"I started thinking about giving the Civil Services exams. I was good in studies, of course, but I was also fascinated by how there were all these students who would give up years of their life to chase a single goal. I didn't know if I could give another Olympic cycle's worth of effort to it, but if only for one year, I wouldn't mind feeling that same emotion as they seemed to be," she says.

Before she decided to call it a day, though, Manu felt there was one last chance to be taken. She took out her phone and made a call to a person

who, in the public imagination, might have been considered the trigger for one of the lowest periods in her career.

On the other end of the line was Jaspal Rana.

"Yes, Manu, what can I do for you?"

"I would like you to coach me once again."

It would be an understatement to say that Rana was taken aback by the call. He says he couldn't believe his



AT 16, MANU BECAME THE YOUNGEST INDIAN TO WIN GOLD AT THE ISSF SHOOTING WORLD CUP



eyes when he saw who the call was from. Two years had passed since a very public falling out between the two.

Most of Manu's life has been lived in the public eye ever since she broke into the sports media news circle for the first time in 2018, when she became the youngest Indian to win gold at the ISSF shooting World Cup at just 16 years old.

Over the years, Manu's life seemed to be synonymous with shooting. "I think a lot of athletes would relate to this. Every aspect of my life was associated with shooting somewhere. I still remember my age based on the tournaments I competed in and won. When I was 16, I won the Commonwealth Games. When I was 17, I won the Olympic quota. When I was 19, I made my debut at the Olympics," she says.

But if her impressive highs marked her out as one of the most prodigious Indian shooting talents, her lows — equally spectacular in their own way — had also been on full display.

Just months before the Tokyo Olympics, Rana, a former two-time Olympian and one of the country's

top pistol shooters in the 1990s and at the turn of the millennium, had helmed a highly successful Indian junior program. He had been Manu's coach ever since she made her international debut in 2018.

Manu had been training with him when she qualified in both the 10m pistol and 25m pistol events for the Olympics. The Federation wanted to send her in both events. But Rana wanted another talented protege of his — Chinki Yadav — to compete in the 25m pistol so that Manu could focus on the 10m pistol event and the 10m pistol mixed team event with Saurabh Chaudhary.

Rana still stands by his decision. "Manu wasn't ready to compete in three different events at such a young age. It's hugely taxing on the body. You can compete in all three, but there's always a compromise to be made. If you train for the 25m pistol events, it always has a negative impact on your 10m pistol chances. We had the chance for an assured

